

Pokémon TCG would make its way to North America in 1999, with *Wizards of the Coast* taking on publishing rights for the game.



Ash Ketchum, the boy who never ages

Credit where credit is due, it would be the anime that would push Pokémon to where it is now, quickly becoming a household staple for children of the time. The first Pokémon movie, *Mewtwo Strikes Back*, which was released in 1999, even held the record for the highest-grossing opening for an animated film in the United States for a short while.

The Pokémon games use a complex rock-paper-scissors system, only, instead of three elements, there are 18 currently. Each element is strong and weak vs several elements, and then there are Pokémon who belong to two elements at the same time, which could make them even weaker to certain elements, or make it so they aren't weak to certain elements anymore. Additionally, Pokémon aren't limited to moves of their own element, a fire-type Pokémon could possibly learn a flying-type move, as long as it was within reason. Same with Water and Ice or Ground and Rock.

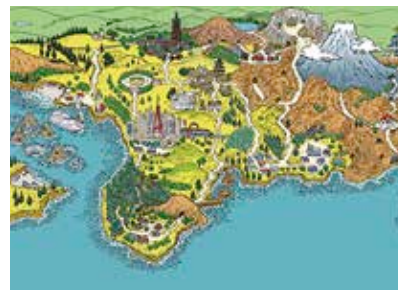
Another thing that was established in this time was that *Pikachu* was a fan favourite; understandably, it's one of the most popular and recognisable characters of all time at this point. Naturally, *Pikachu* was now the franchise's official mascot.

Gen 1 of Pokémon was explosive, and had a lot going for it, so much that we would need an encyclopaedia to cover everything. Before *Gen 2* came around, we would see several Pokémon spin-offs like *Pokémon Stadium* for instance, a few more movies, entirely new game concepts like *Hey You! Pikachu* and *Pokémon Snap*, and even an anime-based musical called *Pokémon Live!*

Gen 2 - Of course, it doesn't end there

There's no way things were stopping at 151 Pokémon. Heck, *Ho-Oh* (Pokémon #250) was teased in the very first episode of the anime, and the first movie teased many Pokémon from the upcoming second gen. It was pretty obvious *Gen 2* was happening, and come November 1999, Nintendo would release *Pokémon Gold* and *Silver* in Japan, for the new Game Boy Colour. Taking place in a new land – *Jhoto* – *Pokémon Gold* and *Silver* would introduce a slew of new mechanics to the Pokémon games. It would be the first game to introduce genders for Pokémon, which in turn allowed for Pokémon breeding for the first time. It was also the first game to introduce a time system in the game, with day-and-night cycles and a real-time clock. This allowed for different events to take place during the day and at night, and on certain days of the week. *Pokémon Gold* and *Silver* would also introduce a friendship system and the concept of 'shiny' Pokémon to the game, with the iconic *Red Gyarados* at the *Lake of Rage*. Even if you're not familiar with it from the games, you should be familiar with it from the anime. Players could also return to *Kanto* and face gym leaders from the original games. *Pokémon Gold* and *Silver* would be released in North America almost one year later, in October

2000. An eventual third version called *Pokémon Crystal* would release in December 2000 (July, 2001 in N.A.), and would be the first Pokémon game



A map of the Johto region

to feature animations for every Pokémon. It would also be the first game to allow trainers to choose their character's gender.

Gen 3 - Advancements incoming

Like with *Gen 2*, there were plenty of hints to confirm the upcoming 3rd gen of Pokémon. In November 2002, the new generation of Pokémon would be released on the *Nintendo Game Boy Advance*, namely, *Pokémon Ruby* and *Sapphire*. A new region to explore, 135 new Pokémon to catch, and of course, a new and more powerful console to make the game look better than ever with plenty of new features. These new features included Double battles, Pokémon Contests, Natures and Abilities for Pokémon, the addition of several new weather types, and of course, the introduction of two new villain teams, *Team Magma* and *Team Aqua*. These games were not backwards compatible like *Pokémon Gold* and *Silver*, because of the extent of the changes to the system.

The new gen was, of course, reflected in the anime as well, with the first episode airing on the day of the game's release in Japan. One of the more significant changes in the anime was the introduction of *May* as a travelling companion, who was based on her game counterpart.

The new generation of consoles meant that a whole host of new Pokémon spin-offs games would also be making their way to the current gener-